Sales Training Debrief — Session 24

The Fortune Is In the Follow-Up. Capture the 50%.

Sales training led by Corie Dawson, Director · Thursday 4 June 2026 · Marketing Sweet

1. The 12-month mindset frame

The session opened with a structural question — how to build a follow-up process that actually works — and the answer started somewhere unexpected: the rep's own time horizon. The pipeline only compounds if the rep believes they'll still be there to harvest it. A rep who sees themselves as short-term cannot run a long-term pipeline strategy; their behaviour reflects their horizon.

> *"Whether you think this is a dead-end job or you think it's a fantastic opportunity, you're right. The pipeline you build matches the horizon you choose."*

How the 12-month frame changes the behaviour:

- Stress on every call drops. A buyer saying "call me back in three months" is no longer a loss — it's a future deal logged.
- The rep stops being desperate for the same-day yes. The 90% who aren't ready today stop feeling like rejections.
- Energy on each call lifts. The rep speaks differently when they believe they have time on their side.
- Three-month chunks are fine — six-month chunks are better — twelve-month chunks are best. Pick a horizon and commit to it.

2. The 10 / 50 / 40 split

The headline statistic of the session, and the framework that justifies everything else. Across a typical day on the phone, the calls break into three groups: a small share of "yes today," a larger share of "interested but not ready," and the remainder telling you to go away.

STAT	WHAT IT MEANS
10%	Yes today. The booking lands inside the conversation. This is the share most reps optimise for — and it's the smallest one.
50%	Interested but not ready. "Call me in three months." "I'm in a contract." "It's bad timing." This is the share most reps ignore — and it's the biggest one.
40%	No. "Not interested." "Stop calling." Tell them you understand, mark them as done, move on. This is the share most reps obsess over.

Why the maths matters:

- Optimising for the 10% caps the rep's potential at 10% of their daily volume.

- Capturing even half of the 50% adds 25% to a rep's monthly conversion — a 2.5x improvement on the same daily activity.
- The 40% never get better. Stop relitigating them. They're a no — accept it and move.
- The 50% are where the real money lives. Most reps walk past it because they can't see it on today's spreadsheet.

> *"Ten percent is closing today. Fifty percent is sitting on the table, untouched. That's a 5x opportunity. The fortune is in the follow-up."*

3. Commission breath — and how to lose it

A specific failure pattern the session named explicitly. "Commission breath" is the desperation a buyer can hear in a rep's voice when the rep needs the deal today. It comes from short-term thinking — the rep treats every call as if it has to convert immediately. The buyer reads the energy long before they hear the offer, and the energy is what closes the deal or kills it.

What commission breath sounds like:

- Pushing through objections instead of acknowledging them.
- Aggressive same-day commitment requests on a buyer who clearly isn't ready.
- Rapid price reductions to chase a yes.
- Voice tone that climbs as the call goes — getting louder, not calmer.

What replaces it:

- Big energy — confident, relaxed, excited about the conversation, not the close.
- Long-horizon framing — "that's totally fine, let me touch base in three months" said with genuine warmth.
- The rep's belief that this call is one of many they'll have with this person — not the only one.

4. The ghost — and the daily fight against it

The session's name for the inner voice that tells reps they're wasting their time. Every rep has it. The ghost is the talker-out — the voice that says "this isn't worth it, the buyer isn't going to convert, this whole pipeline thing is a fantasy." The ghost runs on tiredness, bad calls, and the absence of immediate reward.

> *"The ghost will talk you out of everything. It's like gravity — the easy thing is to sit still and listen to it. The hard thing is to notice it's talking and ignore it."*

How to spot and dismiss the ghost:

1. Notice the thought. "This is a waste of time." That's the ghost — name it.
2. Run the maths instead. "This buyer's a 50% — that's a future deal, not a waste."
3. Remember whose time it is. The rep is paid for the hour. The agency is paying for the long-game work — it's not the rep's call to declare it wasted.
4. Stack the next action. If the ghost says "give up," the antidote is to make one more call. Action quiets the ghost faster than reasoning with it.

5. The fortune is in the follow-up — operationalised

The phrase is famous. The execution is rare. The session laid out exactly what "follow-up" actually looks like as a daily mechanic — not a vague aspiration. The follow-up has structure, language, and a defined cadence.

The three-step follow-up process:

5. On the first call — get permission to send something. "Would you be upset if I sent you some interesting findings now?" The buyer almost always says yes — "upset" makes "no" feel melodramatic.
6. Send the report immediately. While the buyer is still warm. Include something specific — ideally a critique of their current provider that creates curiosity.
7. Get permission to follow up in two weeks. "Would you be upset if I touched base with you in two weeks?" The two-week frame is psychologically light — it feels far enough away to not threaten the buyer's current commitment.

Why the structure matters:

- Permission is the foundation. Without explicit yes-to-follow-up, the rep has no door back in.
- The hand grenade (competitor critique) creates a reason for the buyer to take the call. Curiosity beats persistence.
- The two-week cadence is short enough to keep the conversation alive, far enough to feel non-threatening.

6. The two-week rule

A specific psychological lever. "Two weeks" is short enough to feel like real continuity but far enough away that the buyer's defences stay down. A buyer who would refuse a one-week follow-up — or freeze at "tomorrow" — will agree to two weeks without resistance. It's a calibrated distance.

> *"Two weeks is psychologically a million miles away. Try it. Say two weeks and you've unlocked the gate to seeing them again — and that's all you're doing. You just want permission to speak again."*

How to use the two-week frame:

- Use it as the default follow-up cadence after a permission-to-send conversation.
- Use it as the bridge when a buyer has agreed to be re-contacted later but the rep wants closer contact.
- Use it when offering a calendar choice — "two weeks, or next week if you prefer" — and accept whichever they pick.
- Never compress it to one week without a clear buyer signal. The compression triggers defence.

7. Fall on their own sword — let them choose

The session's framing for how to make follow-up requests without applying pressure. Don't decide for the buyer. Don't say "can I call you" (yes/no answer the rep doesn't control). Say "would you be upset if I called you" — and present the options openly. The buyer can opt out cleanly. The buyer can opt in cleanly. Either answer serves the rep.

> *"Don't make the decision for them. Show them the pathways and let them fall on their own sword. The choice they make is the information."*

The structure of a fall-on-the-sword ask:

- Pre-acknowledge what the buyer already said. "I understand you don't want to do business with us right now — totally get that."
- Present the option warmly. "Would you be upset if I sent you some interesting findings?"
- Give the genuine out. "I'm happy not to call you — there's no pressure."
- Wait for the answer. The buyer either takes the option or declines — both are useful.

8. The asymmetric value hook — competitor critique

The single sharpest tactic in the session for getting follow-up engagement. Once permission is granted, the rep sends not just a generic report but a report that includes specific observations about what the buyer's current provider could be doing better. This creates curiosity that pulls the buyer toward the follow-up call — not pressure that pushes them away from it.

The framing:

- Frame it as helping the buyer get the most out of their current arrangement. "Even if you stay with your provider, here's how you can make them work harder for you."
- Position the rep as a guide, not a competitor. The rep gains credibility — and the buyer becomes invested in seeing the rep's analysis.
- The buyer often calls back angry at their provider for not delivering what the report shows. That's the deal materialising.
- Even when the current provider responds and improves, the rep has positioned themselves as the trusted alternative. The next contract cycle is theirs.

9. The slow burn — and Mario Brothers

The metaphor the session used to explain pipeline patience. Most reps treat sales like a race to a finish line — "close today or lose." The session reframed it as a 365-day game where opportunities are distributed evenly across the year, and the rep's job is to keep walking through the level and collecting coins — not to scoop them all up on screen one.

> *"The coins aren't all in one spot. They're distributed throughout the level. As long as you keep moving forward, they appear. Stop moving, and they don't."*

What slow-burn pipeline behaviour looks like:

- Topping up the pipeline daily — never coasting because "next month looks full."
- Treating every "call me in three months" as a future deal already logged.
- Tracking pipeline against a 12-month horizon — not weekly conversion.

- Reaching the stage where the rep doesn't need today's booking because next week, the week after, and three months from now are already loaded.

10. Buyers are liars — don't read at face value

A directness the session insisted on. "Buyers are liars" doesn't mean buyers are bad people. It means buyers say things to manage their own emotional safety — and the rep who takes their words literally gets played by them. The car-buying example: a buyer who really wants the car will play it cool. A buyer who isn't interested will sometimes be effusively polite. Read behaviour, not language.

> *"Don't be interested in what they say — be interested in what they do. The enthusiastic call that goes nowhere is them softening the breakup. The flat-toned call that asks specific questions is the live deal."*

Specific examples from the session:

- Buyer says "I love what you're doing, you're amazing" with no follow-up action → soft no, dressed up to spare feelings.
- Buyer plays it cool and asks for a price negotiation → strong yes, just posturing.
- Buyer says "call me back in three months" with no specific reason → likely soft no.
- Buyer says "call me back in three months — I'm in a contract until [date]" with detail → genuine stall, follow up confidently.

11. Action items this week

8. Pick a horizon. Commit to it. Tell yourself you're here for twelve months — or six, or three, whatever lands honestly — and run the pipeline against it.
9. Track the 10/50/40 split for your own calls this week. Compare your actual to the model. The 50% bucket is your target.
10. On every "call me in three months" this week, run the full three-step follow-up sequence — permission to send, immediate send, two-week follow-up.
11. Use the phrase "would you be upset if" on at least three follow-up asks this week. Notice the difference in conversion.
12. Build the asymmetric value hook into the next five follow-up emails — name something specific the buyer's current provider could be doing better.
13. Catch the ghost in real time. When you notice "this is a waste of time," name it, run the maths, and make one more call.

THE ONE-LINER 10% close today. 50% close later. The 50% is the fortune. Capture it with permission, curiosity, and the two-week rule.